We had some 6000 mules in service in the forward areas and about half that number in reserve in various depots. As a first step, I immediately ordered a halt to any new breeding of mules. The next step was to gradually reduce the number of mules or relocate them to areas where the maintenance cost would be lower. With a lifespan of anywhere between thirty to forty years, it would still take us two decades-plus till the last mule was 'retired'. Till then, this wasteful expenditure and burden on the revenue budget will continue. A much faster way would be to give them gratis to various states and establishments, the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board for example, who might find better use for them. I give this example only to highlight that there could be many such areas where interior economy can be exercised, but the catalyst for that must come from within. Even if five to ten men (1 per cent) are reduced from each unit, it would amount to a considerable reduction in the overall strength of the Army. There is no magic wand.

Restructuring of Army HQ

The Army HQ is a complex organization and only after having served for at least one tenure in Delhi does one begin the understand the complexities. The HQ itself is in two parts, the majority of the Directorates (Dtes) being in Sena Bhawan, with a few in South Block, primarily those requiring more interaction with the Ministry. There are also strange combinations, e.g., the MI Dte is mostly in Sena Bhawan, but the DGMI sits in South Block. There are many other offices scattered all over, in the hutments around North and South Block (built during WWII—these have been vacated and relocated to KG Marg and Africa Avenue as part of the Central Vista redevelopment plan) as well as other parts of Delhi, including in RK Puram

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